

I66 Timothy

Paul's "own son in the faith," a young leader shaped by a faithful mother and grandmother.

Timothy grew up in Lystra, in what is now central Turkey. His mother was a Jewish believer and his father a Greek. From childhood his mother Eunice and grandmother Lois taught him the Scriptures. When Paul came through Lystra on his second journey, he invited Timothy to join him, and Timothy became his most trusted co-worker for the rest of Paul's life. Paul sent him to steady troubled churches, named him as co-sender of six letters, and wrote two letters to him, urging him to stir up his gift rather than give in to fear. Timothy's life shows how faith passed on at home can grow into a lifetime of service.

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Timotheos</i> , "honoring God"; KJV often "Timotheus"
Family	Mother Eunice; grandmother Lois; Greek father (Acts 16:1)
Home	Lystra, in Lycaonia (Acts 16:1–2)
When	Joins Paul c. AD 49; still serving in the AD 60s
Key places	Lystra, Philippi, Thessalonica, Corinth, Ephesus, Rome
Key people	Paul, Silas, Luke, Lois and Eunice
Main passages	Acts 16:1–5; Philippians 2:19–23; 1–2 Timothy
Co-sender of	Six of Paul's letters, including Philippians

"Let no man despise thy youth; but be thou an example of the believers, in word, in conversation, in charity, in spirit, in faith, in purity."

1 Timothy 4:12, KJV

The life of Timothy

Dates are approximate (AD). Events after Acts come from the letters and cannot be dated closely.

Childhood <i>Lystra</i>	● Raised on Scripture The faith of Lois and Eunice lives in him, and "from a child" he has known the holy scriptures. <i>2 Timothy 1:5; 3:15</i>
c. AD 46–48 <i>First journey</i>	● Paul comes to Lystra Paul is stoned at Lystra. Timothy probably comes to faith then; Paul calls him "my own son in the faith." <i>Acts 14:6–20; 1 Timothy 1:2; 2 Timothy 3:10–11</i>
c. AD 49 <i>Second journey</i>	● Joins Paul Well spoken of by the believers, he joins Paul, who circumcises him because his father is Greek. <i>Acts 16:1–3</i>
c. AD 50 <i>Macedonia</i>	● Sent back to Thessalonica He strengthens the persecuted church and brings Paul good news of their faith. <i>Acts 17:14–15; 18:5; 1 Thessalonians 3:1–6</i>
c. AD 53–57 <i>Third journey</i>	● Paul's troubleshooter Paul sends him from Ephesus to Macedonia and Corinth; later he travels toward Jerusalem. <i>Acts 19:22; 20:4; 1 Corinthians 4:17</i>
c. AD 60–62 <i>Rome</i>	● At Paul's side Named with Paul in prison letters: "I have no man likeminded." <i>Philippians 1:1; 2:19–23; Colossians 1:1; Philemon 1</i>
Later <i>Ephesus</i>	● Left in charge Paul urges him to stay at Ephesus to stop false teaching. <i>1 Timothy 1:3; 3:14–15</i>
c. AD 64–67 <i>Paul's last imprisonment</i>	● Called to come quickly "Do thy diligence to come shortly unto me," bringing Mark, a cloak and the books. <i>2 Timothy 4:9–13, 21</i>

Key activities

Paul's letters show Timothy as loyal and trusted. Many readers also see him as young, timid or often unwell (1 Corinthians 16:10–11; 1 Timothy 4:12; 5:23; 2 Timothy 1:7). These are reasonable inferences, not direct statements.

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- I Learned Scripture at home.** His mother and grandmother passed on the Scriptures and their "unfeigned faith." *2 Timothy 1:5; 3:14–15*

 - 2 Earned a good name.** The believers of Lystra and Iconium spoke well of him before Paul chose him. *Acts 16:2*

 - 3 Gave up comfort for the mission.** He accepted circumcision so that Jewish hearers would not be turned away. *Acts 16:3*

 - 4 Delivered the council's decisions.** With Paul and Silas he carried the Jerusalem decrees to the churches. *Acts 16:4–5*

 - 5 Strengthened a persecuted church.** Paul sent him "to establish you, and to comfort you concerning your faith." *1 Thessalonians 3:2*

 - 6 Preached Christ at Corinth.** Paul names him as a preacher there with Silvanus. *2 Corinthians 1:19*

 - 7 Represented Paul.** Paul sent him, "faithful in the Lord," to remind the Corinthians of his ways. *1 Corinthians 4:17*

 - 8 Shared in Paul's letters.** He is named as co-sender of six of Paul's letters. *2 Corinthians 1:1; Philippians 1:1; Philemon 1*

 - 9 Cared genuinely for others.** Paul said he would "naturally care" for the Philippians. *Philippians 2:20–22*

 - 10 Led the church at Ephesus.** He was charged to guard sound teaching, choose qualified leaders and care for widows. *1 Timothy 1:3; 3:1–13; 5:3–16*

 - II Guarded his gift.** Paul urged him to stir up the gift given with the laying on of hands and not to be ashamed. *1 Timothy 4:14; 2 Timothy 1:6–8*

 - 12 Suffered for the faith.** Hebrews reports that "our brother Timothy is set at liberty," apparently from prison. *Hebrews 13:23*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Eusebius's "first bishop of Ephesus" is tradition.

Old Testament

2 Timothy 3:15	The "holy scriptures" he knew were the Old Testament
Echo: Numbers 11:28	Joshua served Moses from his youth
Echo: Jeremiah 1:6–8	"I am a child," yet God sent him

New Testament

Acts 16:1–5; 17:14–15; 18:5; 19:22; 20:4	His travels with Paul
1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10–11	Sent to Corinth; "Let no man therefore despise him"
Philippians 2:19–22	"I have no man likeminded"
1 and 2 Timothy	Paul's letters to him; authorship debated by scholars
Hebrews 13:23	"Our brother Timothy is set at liberty"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Who first taught Timothy the Scriptures (2 Timothy 1:5; 3:15)?
2. *Understand:* Why might example matter more than age (1 Timothy 4:12)?
3. *Apply:* Who passed faith on to you? Who could you pass it on to this month?
4. *Apply:* Where is fear holding you back from something God has given you to do (2 Timothy 1:7)?